DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

# What Are the Four Ages of Humanity?

Derech Hashem 2:8:4-5

**Sefer:** Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 8, paragraphs 4-5, and Chapter 7, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 30 August 2021

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## Review

Last class the Ramhal taught that Hashem's influence is not only on physical things but on spiritual things too. He described a utopia and its opposite, with our world somewhere in between, and explained that the root of all good and bad is the illumination or concealment of Hashem's face. The aim today was to finish Chapter 8, which consists of separate points about hashgahah.

## Paragraph 4: four stages of humanity

If we look at the whole history of the world since creation, together with what the prophets foretold about the future, we find four stages. Humanity can be seen as maturing.

**Stage one: great darkness.** A period when darkness and foolishness were so great that knowledge of Hashem was concealed and held back. This is what Hazal call the first two thousand years of desolation (tohu), when there was no Torah and idol worship was rampant. It is the lowest level. Avraham, born in the year 1948 from the creation of Adam, ushers in what comes next.

The Rabbi illustrated the difference Torah makes with a question raised about the Gemara in Hullin. When Rabbi Pinehas ben Yair was on his way to redeem captives, a river split for him. Why do we celebrate the splitting of the sea with a whole festival, yet no one makes much of this? Because the splitting of the sea happened before there was Torah. Once there is Torah, it is not so remarkable that a Tanna can cross a river; he has the power of the Torah.

**Stage two: Torah without prophecy.** Better than the first, and the period we live in now, since the destruction of the Temple. We have understanding of Hashem because we have the Torah, and we serve Him. But "there is no sign and no prophet." We lack ruah hakodesh. It is possible to comprehend Hashem through the intellect, but the Ramhal says that what a person grasps with his own intellect, compared with what he grasps through direct Divine influence, is like the body compared with the soul. We have Torah, knowledge and science, and these are good things, but not directness. "Attaining understanding of God through philosophy and through knowledge and through Torah, to realising it through actual experience... you can't compare the two." Prophecy, the subject of Part 3, means experiencing Hashem.

**Stage three: the Temple period.** Better still. There was prophecy and there were wonders. But only for individuals, and even for them it was very difficult: as Part 3 will explain, prophets would fall to the ground and lose their faculties, because they were physical. A participant recalled the young Shemuel, sleeping near Eli, hearing a voice three times and not understanding. Every prophet lost his senses except Moshe Rabbenu, to whom Hashem spoke "mouth to mouth."

**Stage four: the future.** What the prophets foretold: there will be no more foolishness, and ruah hakodesh will rest upon all humanity without difficulty. "People will just feel intense God." Then humanity will have reached its maturity, and from there it will only progress.

A participant asked whether in that time people would reach the level of Moshe. The Rabbi said each person would experience Hashem according to his level, but it will be easy, because the barrier of the body will be gone; the body will have been refined. Falling, sleeping and trembling during prophecy happen because of the body. Whether this is the best possible state he did not know; a soul with no barriers at all may be higher still. It is the best that the world has seen.

## Paragraph 5: time, place and conditions

The final separate point: the spiritual influence follows laws relating to time, place and other conditions. - **Time:** certain times have special spiritual energy, such as Shabbat, the first night of Pesah, Yom Kippur. - **Place:** there is more spiritual energy in a holy place. The Rabbi explained that it is not that the stones of the Kotel are holier than any others, but because of what has happened there historically, there is more influence to tap into there. - **Other conditions:** for example, the Gemara says the air of the Land of Israel makes one wise.

Hashem created a system in which He reveals Himself at certain times and places, and in certain ways, and not at others, with precise details fitting for humanity. This explains the holiness of days and places, where there is more illumination, refinement and advantage. It will be explained further in Part 4.

The Rabbi added that time and space are always intertwined. The second order of the Mishnah is Moed, "times": Shabbat, Sukkah, Rosh Hashanah, Yoma. And the holiest place in the Torah is the Ohel Moed, the tent of meeting. A participant pointed out that within Shabbat itself, much of Masekhet Shabbat and the whole of Eruvin deal with carrying, a melakhah defined by space.

## Chapter 8 in five points

The Rabbi summarised the chapter: 1. Hashem has bound Himself to the system of mishpat, but sometimes overrides it with hanhagat hayihud; that is what we pray for on Rosh Hashanah. 2. His influence is spiritual as well as material, as the utopia and its opposite show. 3. We live in a physical world, and the more we turn ourselves towards Him, the more illumination there is. 4. There are four stages in human history and future. 5. Spiritual influence varies by place and time, with great precision.

Part 3, on prophecy, begins after Sukkot; Part 4 deals with festivals and Shabbat. First, the skipped Chapter 7.

## Chapter 7: what role does astrology play?

Chapter 7 is about the influence of the stars (hashpaat hakokhavim). What role does astrology play in Torah? Is it true? These questions will be discussed on Thursday.

Paragraph 1 begins with a review of Part 1, Chapter 5: every physical thing has a spiritual root above, called its koah. There is nothing physical in this world, "this table" included, without such a root. Things are rooted above in every way they need to be, and then they must be drawn down into physical existence in the form they need.

Once the influence enters the physical universe, it passes through further filters: the stars, planets and galaxies. They are physical, part of the universe, and they too come from the malakh, from the koah, from Hashem, all one chain. Through them and their cycles, what began in the spiritual world is "copied down" into physical reality. Their number and positions are as Hashem wanted.

A participant asked whether the stars correspond to the Sefirot. The Rabbi said no: the Sefirot belong entirely to the spiritual realm of the koah and the malakhim, beyond the physical universe. "That's Kabbalah... and this is astrology. Two separate things." Whether astrology is true, and what effect the stars have, will be discussed on Thursday, before finishing Part 2 ahead of Rosh Hashanah.

## Summary

- Humanity passes through four stages: the dark years before Torah, Torah without prophecy (today), the Temple period with prophecy for individuals, and a future when all will experience Hashem.
- Knowing Hashem through intellect, even through Torah, is to knowing Him through experience as body is to soul.
- Spiritual influence varies with time, place and conditions; holiness of days and places comes from this, and time and space are intertwined.
- Chapter 8 closes Part 2's discussion of hashgahah with five separate points.
- Chapter 7 begins: every physical thing has a spiritual root, and its influence reaches earth through the stars, which are physical, not Sefirot.

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